

LICENCED TO KILL: Militant outfits like Bajrang Dal have come to represent the face of Hindu terror

leaders too well. "Whether Sadhvi Pragya was a member or not is a technical issue but the fact remains that she followed the Sangh ideology," said a VHP leader, not wanting the BJP to be on the defensive. The discontent among Sangh Parivar cadres was palpable at the usually quiet VHP headquarters at Jhandewalan in the capital. "The party uses us whenever it needs muscle power or lung power or to create a nuisance but at the first sign of trouble, it abandons or sidelines us," complained a Bajrang Dal activist. The Bajrang Dal has been given

FACES OF TERROR

BAJRANG DAL: Youth wing of VHP, founded in 1984. Played a role in the Babri mosque demolition, murder of missionary Graham Staines, and the Gujarat riots.

DURGA VAHINI: Women's wing of Bajrang Dal, set up in 1991 under Sadhvi Ritambhara. Was involved in Babri demolition.

HINDU DEFENCE FORCE: Set up in Gujarat during the 2002 riots, is active in Maharashtra.

JAANTA RAM: An extremist Hindu organisation linked to the Shiv Sena, had a role in Male-

and Purushottam Rupala, respectively, came out in her support, saying she was being framed. Vijayvargiya also came out in support of Shyamlal Sahu, another accused in the blasts case. Sahu, 42, in addition to being a BJP leader, used to run a small mobile recharge voucher and handset vending outlet in Tukoganj area of Indore.

Other Hindu organisations have begun to rally around in support. On October 27, the Akhand Hindu Sena, led by Acharya Shekhar, a senior VHP functionary in Ujjain, held a *yajna* in her support. Meanwhile, some Muslim organisations are demanding that the 2006 Malegaon blasts, which killed 31 people, be reinvestigated with the emergence of "the Hindu face of terror".

In fact, intelligence officials are hard put to explain their failure to pin the earlier Malegaon blasts in 2006 on Hindu outfits. Even then, the finger of suspicion had pointed towards right-wing organisations but at that time it was considered almost impossible that they would execute terror acts. "We knew about their militant nature and also the kind of training being imparted to many of them but we could not believe that they would make bombs and organise blasts in retaliation to Islamic terror," a former IB chief said.

To avoid communal tension and taking the easy way out, Maharashtra Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh handed over the probe to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) in December 2006. Then CBI director Vijay Shanker, on the eve of his retirement, said the unresolved Malegaon blasts was one of the toughest cases he had handled. Without elaborating, he had called it a "tightrope". For the UPA Government and security agencies, getting to grips with the new face of terror will be an even trickier tightrope walk. ■



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space in the vast complex to hold meetings and coordinate with other Sangh outfits.

A senior VHP leader added that the party had a history of disowning those who had become uncomfortable for them. "Even Pravin Togadia has been relegated to the sidelines," he says. Sadhvi Ritambhara, who used to travel with Advani during his rath yatra, is now almost an untouchable for the party leaders.

State party units, however, continue to back the Sadhvi. Unit chiefs of Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat, Kailash Vijayvargiya

gaon riots, 2001 and said to have provided logistical support in the September 2006 blasts.

HINDU MUNNANI: Formed in 1980 as a front organisation of the RSS in Tamil Nadu. Incited riots after the Babri demolition.

RASHTRA JAGRAN MANCH: Formed in 2007 by a break-away group of RSS. Believed to be involved in Malegaon, Modasa and Kanpur blasts.

ABHINAV BHARAT: Formed in 2004. Allegedly involved in Nanded, Malegaon and Modasa blasts.